Title Page

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Title. Who Pays for the Next Attempt? Contract Design and Escalation Rules for AI-Assisted Software Maintenance

Running header. Who Pays for the Next Attempt?

Manuscript type. Research Article

Authors and affiliations. [Author 1 name, title, department, institution, city, country]; [Author 2 name, …]

Corresponding author. [Name, postal address, e-mail address, telephone]

ORCID of the submitting author. [https://orcid.org/xxxx-xxxx-xxxx-xxxx]

Keywords. AI–human task allocation; escalation; outcome-based pricing; IT service contracts; software maintenance; large language models; double marginalization; optimal stopping *(map these to the ScholarOne keyword list at submission)*

Length. Abstract: 296 words. Main text before the references: about 8,570 words (the manuscript is formatted in 11-point type, double-spaced, with one-inch margins). An online appendix accompanies the paper.

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Disclosure of AI assistance. [Describe the use of generative AI tools in preparing the text, the analysis code, and the data, in line with the INFORMS policy on AI use; see the cover letter.]